

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography in romantasy serves a dual function. It builds a believable world, sure, but it also does something more intimate: it determines if your characters can ever meet one another. A mountain range separating two kingdoms is not simply a border. It creates the only viable opportunity for an alliance through marriage. That isolated academy isn't just a cool setting. The isolation of the academy is the reason why your character can't leave this person who infuriates her.

Every river, every desert, every castle wall in your world will be either drawing your characters closer together or keeping them apart. Build geography with that in mind, and your setting ceases to be a passive backdrop and begins to create your story.

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation covers the physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance covers how physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system**. The physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you foreground, the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances between them, should be

doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

The “Pressure Cooker” Principle

The best romantasy settings act like pressure cookers: environments that create friction between your characters by compressing them together, holding them apart, or forcing impossible choices. In situations where the physical world limits your characters’ ability to move away from one another, escape each other’s company, or take the path of least resistance, then your setting has done half of the work to create the relationship.

Geography creates friction in three ways.

Proximity friction forces characters together despite themselves. A snowed-in mountain pass, a ship voyage with no escape, an isolated academy, a dangerous journey requiring partnership. When your characters can’t leave each other alone, then they will be forced to confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defences. It is the small things that add up. Shared meals. Overheard conversations. Accidental touches in tight quarters.

That is why Basgiath War College works so well in *Fourth Wing*. The war college is literally carved into the side of rugged cliffs, and even getting in requires surviving the Parapet, a lethal crossing that establishes the stakes before classes even begin. Once you’re inside, there’s no leaving. The sparring gym forces mandatory physical contact. The dorms provide little to no private space. And when Violet’s and Xaden’s dragons turn out to be mates, their biology adds yet another layer of confinement; the riders physically can’t stay apart for more than a few days without suffering for it. The combination of the environment and the bond between the two creates a situation where the characters cannot remain separated from each other. As a result, these two have to deal with each other whether they want to or not. The setting generates the romance.

Separation friction will keep your characters separated as well as physically apart from each other. An ocean that takes months to cross, separate kingdoms behind a mountain range, a magical barrier that requires certain conditions for safe passage, war zones that make travel deadly. Separation makes physical separation feel heavy and the distance meaningful. Each time someone leaves and returns the experience is emotionally charged, and the question of who’ll cross the divide (and what it costs them) becomes a declaration in itself.

Resource friction presents obstacles that both characters have to overcome. Rights to use limited water resources in a desert area, the only pass through the mountains, a rare magical resource found

in contested territory, trade routes that require cooperation between enemies. As long as the people your characters represent are at odds over a piece of geography, the romantic relationship will have to find a way to address this tension whether either party wants to or not.

Now consider what seals the pressure cooker tight in your world:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, schools, sieges, ships, remote estates. Places with real boundaries that your characters cannot cross.
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Wilderness that requires your characters to partner to survive, diplomatic missions, shared exile. Situations where separating means failure or death.
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, magic that prevents your characters from leaving. Forces outside of your characters that make leaving impossible no matter their wishes.
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, obligations to the courts. Scenarios in which leaving would result in harm to their reputation, alliances or the lives of others.

You may feel that if your geography does not cause friction for your characters then the geography is wasted space; however, this is not necessarily true. It's just setting. But the geography that you choose to focus on should be causing your characters to come together, pulling them apart, or forcing them to choose. If your characters could simply leave each other behind, would they? If the answer is yes, your geography needs to make it impossible, too dangerous or too costly for them to do so.

The Pressure Cooker: Your Story

What type of geographic friction does your romance need most?

Think about the core dynamic of your love story. Do your characters need to be trapped together (proximity), kept apart (separation), or forced to negotiate over something (resource)? Most romances use more than one, but one tends to dominate.

What type of geographic friction does your romance use most — proximity, separation, or resource? How does it show up in your story, and what does it force your characters to do?

YOUR ANSWER

What seals the pressure cooker in your world?

Check the trapping types that apply and describe how they work in your story. The strongest setups use more than one.

TRAPPING TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
Physical (islands, walls, academies)		

TRAPPING TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
Circumstantial (must partner to survive)		
Environmental (storms, seasons, magic)		
Social/political (obligations, hostage, arranged marriage)		

Could your characters simply walk away from each other?

If the answer is yes, your pressure cooker has a leak. What makes leaving impossible, too dangerous, or too costly?

YOUR ANSWER

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Characters live, train, and compete in close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>
The Isolated Estate	Limited cast, limited space, limited options for avoidance	Gothic romances, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variations
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container with enforced proximity and shared danger	Pirate romance, trade caravan stories
The Siege/War Camp	External threat forces cooperation; death is the alternative	Military romantasy
The Prison/Captivity	Hostage and captor, shared cell, or trapped in enemy territory together	Captive romance, enemies-to-lovers
The Dangerous Quest	Mission requires partnership; separating means failure or death	Quest narratives, escort missions
The Snowed-In/Stranded	Weather or disaster traps characters until conditions change	Cabin romance, “only one bed”
The Royal Court	Political obligations, arranged proximity, can’t leave without scandal	Court intrigue, political marriage

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one can't
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines
Cursed/Blighted lands	Regions too dangerous to cross; require special protection	Must find another way; one character immune, one isn't
Class geography	Slums vs. palace district; social ruin to cross	Wrong-side-of-tracks romance; secret meetings in between spaces

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Extreme heat	Travel only possible at night; requires shade-sharing, water rationing	Night travel intimacy; sharing precious water; heat exhaustion care
Hostile territory after dark	Monsters or predators hunt at night; must camp together for safety	One bed/bedroll situations; taking turns on watch; protective instincts
Corrupted/poisoned land	Regions that drain magic or health; must move quickly or rely on healer	Dependency on one character's abilities; racing against deterioration

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Rubber-Band World

Geography bends to suit the plot. Characters travel vast distances between chapters with no sense of time passing, and geographic features appear or disappear as needed. A mountain range exists to separate characters but conveniently vanishes when they need to reunite. If distance has no weight, separation has no stakes and reunion carries no emotional punch. Barriers that can be waved away whenever it's convenient are barriers readers stop believing in. The geography that's supposed to keep your characters apart needs to feel immovable, or the tension of being apart means nothing.

FIX

Establish your geography and travel times early, then let them constrain you. If crossing the mountains takes three weeks, that's three weeks of separation your characters have to live with, or three weeks of travelling together that changes everything. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for. Those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #2: The Empty Map

You've got a map with named places, but none of them feel lived-in. The geography exists, but it doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference.

Mistake #3: Geography Without Emotional Resonance

You describe the setting in detail, but it’s all physical. Mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different from other places. The character’s homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like a prison to one character and a sanctuary to another.

Geography Self-Check

Review the geography you’ve built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Rubber-Band World: Travel times or distances change to suit the plot		
Empty Map: Locations exist but don’t affect culture, conflict, or character		

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
No Emotional Resonance: Setting is described physically but never connected to how characters feel		

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

What's the geographic scope of your story?

Check the scope that best fits your story, then note the primary locations where your romance actually takes place.

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
<i>Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)</i>	✓	<i>Thornwick Academy — a remote magical school on sea cliffs where students are trapped together for the term</i>
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)		
Single region (kingdom, province, territory)		

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Multiple regions (nations, continents)		
Entire world (epic scope)		
Multiple worlds/realms (parallel dimensions, portals)		
Other: Describe		

If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?

You don't need to detail everything — just locations that matter.

List your primary and secondary locations. For each, give the name and a one-sentence description of what happens there and why it matters to the romance.

YOUR ANSWER

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

This is reference material. Fill in what you know now; come back as your world develops.

Describe your primary kingdom/nation. What is it called, what is it known for, what is its main resource, and how does it create or complicate your love story? If you have a second kingdom, describe it too.

YOUR ANSWER

If your world has additional kingdoms or nations, describe them here. What is each called, what distinguishes it, and how does it matter to the romance?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the relationship between these kingdoms/nations affect your romance?

Are your characters from rival nations? Allied ones? Does one kingdom control something the other needs? The political geography between nations often becomes the romantic geography between lovers.

YOUR ANSWER

Terrain Types

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

For each major terrain type in your world, describe where it is, what it provides, what challenges it creates, and how it affects the romance.

YOUR ANSWER

Naming Places

Good place names make your world feel real. You don't need to invent a whole language for this; just notice how real places get their names.

Most come from geography (Blackwood, Riverside), historical figures (Washington), or descriptions in old languages (Oxford means "ford where oxen cross"). Borrow the patterns, not the exact words.

In romantasy, naming matters most when your characters come from different cultures. Distinct naming conventions instantly signal "these people are not the same," and a character learning to pronounce names from their love interest's language, or discovering what a place name means, can be a quiet intimacy beat. If your two kingdoms share naming patterns, readers will assume shared heritage. If the names feel completely alien to each other, readers feel the cultural distance your characters have to cross.

Researching Naming Conventions

If you want place names that evoke a particular culture or aesthetic, here's how to find patterns yourself:

- **Search "[language] place name meanings"** e.g., "Old Norse place name meanings" or "Welsh place name elements"
- **Search "[language] words for [terrain]"** e.g., "Japanese words for mountain" or "Gaelic words for river"
- **Look up real places.** Search "etymology of [real place name]" to see how actual names were constructed.
- **Wikipedia's toponymy pages.** Search "[language] toponymy" for organised lists of place name elements.
- **Behind the Name.** The website [behindthename.com](https://www.behindthename.com) has a place names section with etymologies.

For deeper language work, see *Section 11: Language & Communication*.

Reference: Common English Place Name Patterns

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. "Ash" + "ford" = Ashford. "Black" + "moor" = Blackmoor.

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
-ton / -town	fenced settlement	Brighton
-ford	river crossing	Oxford
-ley / -leigh	clearing, meadow	Barnsley
-dale / -vale	valley	Airedale
-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
-port	harbor, market town	Southport
-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
-fell / -mount	hill, mountain	Scafell
-holme / -holm	island, water meadow	Stockholm

Reference: Nordic/Scandinavian Place Name Patterns

Good for cold, northern, Viking-inspired settings. Old Norse roots appear in many English place names too.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-by	farm, settlement	Whitby, Grimsby
-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik, Lerwick
-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
-dal / -dalen	valley	Gudvangen

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
-stad / -sted	place, site	Halstead
-land	land, territory	Iceland, Gotland
-thwaite	clearing, meadow	Braithwaite

Reference: Celtic/Welsh Place Name Patterns

Good for mystical, ancient, fae-adjacent settings. Celtic names often describe landscape features poetically.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen, Aberystwyth
Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Caernarfon, Cardiff
Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno
Pen-	head, top, end	Penrith, Penzance
Tre- / Tref-	homestead, town	Tremaine
Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Edinburgh (Dun Edin)
-combe / -cwm	valley	Ilfracombe
Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe
Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Inver- / Innis-	river mouth / island	Inverness

Reference: Slavic Place Name Patterns

Good for Eastern European-inspired settings. Slavic names often use descriptive compounds.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade, Novgorod
-ov / -ova / -ovo	belonging to (possessive)	Sarajevo, Krakow
Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Staro- / Stary-	old	Starograd
-pol / -pole	field	Sevastopol
Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade (Beograd)
Cerno- / Chern-	black	Chernobyl
-ice / -itz	place suffix	Katowice
-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk, Minsk
Veliko- / Veliky-	great, large	Veliky Novgorod

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create prefixes and suffixes that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

Create 3-5 naming elements (prefixes or suffixes) for your world's place names. For each, note the meaning and give an example of a location name that uses it.

YOUR ANSWER

Name your key locations

Use the patterns above (or your own) to name the places that matter most. If you already have names, write them here and note what they mean or evoke.

Name your key locations (protagonist's homeland, love interest's homeland, where they meet, the contested territory, their special place). For each, explain what the name means and which naming convention it follows.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters' naming conventions signal cultural distance?

If your characters come from different cultures, distinct naming patterns instantly tell readers "these people are not the same." Would someone from Kingdom A struggle to pronounce names from Kingdom B?

YOUR ANSWER

Where could naming differences create a quiet intimacy beat?

A character stumbling over an unfamiliar name, asking what a place name means, or learning that their love interest's homeland translates to something beautiful — these are small moments that build closeness. Where in your story could the act of learning someone's language or place names become a romantic gesture?

YOUR ANSWER

Resources & Territorial Control

Geography tells us who has what and thus who has the ability to have power. Fertile land, fresh water, mineral deposits, trade routes: all of these are valuable enough to fight wars over, to marry for, to die for.

Resource control is probably the most consistent engine for romantic conflict within romantasy. It's behind an arranged marriage to secure a trade route, the tribute that a king demands from a conquered kingdom, the alliance sealed by sending a princess to a court she despises. But resource control does not have to be limited to kingdoms and their battles over land and resources. A character who finds out that their kingdom has been exploiting their love interest's homeland, or who has a monopoly on the one resource that the other's people desperately need. When there is an imbalance of resources there is also a perceived imbalance of power, which is why this works so well.

The most effective way to demonstrate resource control on the page is to show what your characters can and cannot do, rather than telling them through exposition. For instance, a character from a land that has very little water may flinch every time they see someone leaving a tub of water running. If there is a war for control of a particular piece of land because of its strategic location for trade, then

someone who is aware of this will notice the strategic advantage where others just view it as beautiful. This awareness should show itself through small reactions, casual conversations about prices or lack thereof, and the constant underlying anxiety that people in this world experience about resources. The tension that develops between two characters when one comes from a side of the battle for resources and the other comes from the opposing side will always develop in their assumptions about each other, what they choose not to comment about, and the times when privilege becomes visible.



Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble, quality building stone
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits, chocolate/cacao
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells (Tyrian purple), ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee, tobacco, opium
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components, phoenix feathers, dragon scales
Curiosities	Fossils, adder stones, meteoric iron, ancient artifacts, bottled starlight, tears of gods

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?

Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What scarcity shapes daily life?

What are the 2-3 most important natural resources in your world? For each, describe where it's found, who controls it, and how that control creates conflict or tension in your story.

YOUR ANSWER

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Trade routes? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples?

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

Resources & Scarcity You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In Section 4: *Resources & Scarcity*, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

The Sensory World

Geography doesn't just mean what exists in space; it also means how it feels to be in that space. Those sensory elements of your setting contribute to the emotional texture of scenes. A first kiss will have a different quality to it when done in a garden filled with the scent of night-blooming jasmine as opposed to a stone hallway with torch smoke.

You want to filter the sensory details you are including through your POV character's emotional state. A person in love will notice the warmth of sun on their skin, the sweet fragrance of flowers, and the softness of the grass beneath them. On the other hand, a grieving character will see the same garden as being too light, the flower fragrance overpowering, and the bird song annoyingly loud. Do not attempt to include every detail of a scene. Choose two or three sensory elements that help to establish the mood of each scene you write and then let the rest fade away.

Something to be aware of is the "weather report" style of beginning a scene. This is when you describe your setting using neutral language before anything has happened. By incorporating the sensory elements into the action and emotions of your characters, you will create a stronger scene. Instead of saying "The room was cold," say "She tightened her cloak around her body, breath misting in the unheated chamber." As a character interacts with the world, the way they interact with it creates both the setting of the scene and the feelings of the character simultaneously.



What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?

Close your eyes and walk through this place. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

Close your eyes and walk through your primary setting. Describe what you see, hear, smell, and feel (temperature, humidity, wind).

YOUR ANSWER

How does the environment change at different times of day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here?

Most dangerous?

How does your primary setting change throughout the day? Describe it at morning, midday, evening, and night – and note what kind of romantic scene would fit each time.

YOUR ANSWER

What's beautiful about this place?

The details a character falling in love would notice. What would make someone homesick for this place?

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

What do people endure or complain about? What takes getting used to?

YOUR ANSWER

Climate, Weather & Seasons

The weather is a form of immediate, physical, environmental condition, which affects everything from how people move through the world, their ability to grow food, warfare, and their day-to-day lives. In addition to providing these barriers to possibility, seasons can provide a deadline (marry before the snow blocks the pass) or a waiting period (trapped together until the spring thaw), or simply mark the passage of time as they navigate their long-term attraction to one another.

Using seasonal events to show the passage of time is a nice way to avoid stating the obvious. The first frost. The smell of rain after months of drought. The way the angle of the sun changes every week. Weather is most effective in romantic stories when it creates some kind of immediate physical problem that both characters have to deal with together: wet clothes that need to come off, cold that needs to be warmed, heat that irritates. Do not simply tell the reader about the weather. Have the characters react to it, complain about it, make decisions based on it.

In addition, seasonal changes can also reflect changes in emotions beautifully. A couple whose relationship begins to thaw as the last of winter melts away. Tensions that build as the temperatures rise with summer. A reckoning that arrives with autumn.



What's the overall climate?

Climate shapes daily life, which shapes your characters' interactions. Tropical heat, bitter cold, endless rain — each creates different physical problems that your characters may need to solve together.

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

Pick the most story-relevant season in your world. What does this season make possible, and what does it make impossible?

YOUR ANSWER

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

For each season (summer/warm, winter/cold, transitional), what becomes possible and what becomes impossible in your world?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

Every world has places that are deadly, and therefore avoided, or crossed only with preparation and company. Dangerous regions serve romance by raising stakes and forcing partnership. When two characters find themselves needing to travel across hostile territory together, survival becomes the only priority, and the walls people maintain in civilised settings collapse fast.

But the danger has to land. If your characters trek through the Deadly Wastes and emerge fine, readers stop believing the world is dangerous, and if they don't believe the danger, they don't believe your characters need each other to survive it. So let the environment cause damage to your characters: exhaustion, injury, rationed supplies, wrong turns, real fear. Write one character's competence saving the other. Write one character's vulnerability forcing the other to step up. What occurs after your characters survive some horrible event together forever changes their relationship, so make sure you give that shift room to breathe on the page.

Creating the decision to venture into dangerous territory as a heavy decision prior to entering helps too. Characters arguing about whether to go, preparing inadequately, or being forced in against their will. The region itself should have a reputation that precedes it: local guides who refuse to help, maps that end at the border, warnings ignored out of desperation. All of that builds dread, and dread makes the romance that blooms inside the danger feel earned.



What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

Describe the most dangerous region in your world. What makes it dangerous, and who goes there anyway (and why)?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?

Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats would force them to rely on each other?

Plan a dangerous journey for your characters. Where do they go and why? What dangers do they face? What damage does the environment cause? What forces them to rely on each other, and what changes between them after surviving it?

YOUR ANSWER

Borders & Boundaries

Borders convert geographic areas to identities. When a mountain range or river is defined as the “line” that separates two groups of people, the people on either side begin to define themselves relative to one another. The creation of a border creates cultural assumptions, political tension, and a kind of deep-seated distrust that leads to cross-border romance feeling like something that is strictly prohibited, as opposed to merely inconvenient.

The strongest borders in romantasy are not necessarily lines on a map; they are lines in the minds of the characters. A character raised with the idea that all of the people on the other side of the mountains are barbarians or that no one from the other court can be trusted will have that border inside of them long after the physical one has been crossed. When writing the prejudices that each character holds against the other, make sure they are specific and casual: the assumptions each character makes about the other’s food, manners, values, intelligence. Then write the moments when those assumptions break down.

Also consider the cost of crossing a border for each character. Is crossing considered treason? Social death? Does one character risk everything to cross over while the other side doesn’t even notice? The asymmetry of the cost of the border to each character can lead to the entire romantic arc. Borders can also create “in-between” space: the neutral zone, the disputed land, the meeting point where neither character is quite at home. Many of the most truthful conversations occur in these in-between zones because neither party has the comfort of home base.



What geographic features create borders?

Mountains, rivers, and oceans don't just separate land — they separate peoples, and the assumptions each side makes about the other. The feature you choose shapes how crossable the border feels.

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?

A border that's easy to cross creates a different kind of forbidden love than one that's physically impassable. The harder the crossing, the more it costs — and the more that cost means when someone pays it.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?

Borders create “us” and “them.” What assumptions would each character have about someone from the other side?

What geographic or political border separates your characters? What does crossing it mean (legally, socially, personally), and is there any in-between space where they can meet?

YOUR ANSWER

What assumptions does each character carry about the other side?

The strongest borders are internal. What does each character believe — casually, without thinking — about people from their love interest’s side? And what moment first cracks that assumption?

What does your protagonist assume about the love interest’s people — and what moment shatters that assumption? What does the love interest assume about the protagonist’s people, and when does that break?

YOUR ANSWER

Home & Belonging

One of the most emotionally charged concepts of love is “Home”. The characters may have to travel to find love, may choose between the love they want to have and the comfort of “Home”, may learn that “Home” is wherever the other person is, or may discover that choosing this person means exile from everything familiar.

You can convey this through specific sensory elements and details about the location rather than simply stating that the “place” is important to the character. What is the first thing your character reaches for when they’re homesick? Is there a certain smell that takes your character right back to the time and place that made them feel at home? When you write scenes that take place in your character’s home area, allow them to move with complete ease and familiarity; they know which creaking floorboards they’ll hit, which windows won’t open. Then compare and contrast how your character moves through

unfamiliar environments. Do they hesitate, do they observe their surroundings carefully, do they appear somewhat unsteady?

The emotional tug-of-war between “where I belong” and “where love is taking me” creates some of romance’s most powerful emotional beats. When a character decides to remain in their lover’s world, or asks their lover to join them in their world, that decision is just as profound as any verbal confession of love.

This idea is central to the entire arc of the ACOTAR series. The Spring Court is a beautiful place; eternal sunshine, flowers, whimsy. However, after Feyre’s experience Under the Mountain, the beauty of the Spring Court transforms into a prison. Tamlin cages her inside the manor’s wards, and the beautiful landscape that used to be so romantic now feels confining. She then arrives at the Night Court and encounters Velaris: a hidden city of starlight built along the Sidra River, and an artists’ quarter known as the Rainbow. The topography of Velaris parallels what Rhysand provides for her emotionally; safety, creative freedom, a place that welcomes her powers rather than fearing them. As Feyre travels from the Spring Court to Velaris, her physical sense of “home” reflects her emotional connection to each location and to each relationship. When the Spring Court feels like a prison, that relationship is dying. When Velaris feels like home, the new love has grown roots. The geography tells the reader where Feyre’s heart is long before she acknowledges it to herself.



Where does your protagonist feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean “home”:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they’re most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist’s home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

Where does each of your main characters feel most out of place — alien, uncomfortable, or unwelcome? Why?

YOUR ANSWER

Entering Each Other's Worlds

When your characters are from different areas, sending one to visit the other's territory is a big deal. There is a certain risk of weakness in inviting someone to enter your home grounds. While your new friend will be seeing your world through their eyes, they'll also notice aspects of your world you've grown so accustomed to you no longer even think about. Both the beauty and the flaws are equally present.

As soon as a character visits their love interest's territory, use their outsider perspective to observe everything around them. What confuses them? What do they find impressive? What do they find unsettling? Their reactions reveal both the world and the character at the same time. Conversely, the "native" character will experience a type of vulnerability of their own. They will be made aware of the poverty they had normalised, the privileges they had never even considered, or the customs which, although perfectly logical to themselves, appear bizarre when articulated out loud.

It is the tiny moments of the everyday experience where we can witness the truest display of intimacy. The love interest instinctively reaching to help the visitor perform a task they are unfamiliar with. The visitor mispronouncing a word that everyone around them understands perfectly well. The native character defending their home against criticisms they secretly agree with. All of these “fish-out-of-water” situations create closeness, because they necessitate explanations, patience and the trust to allow oneself to appear foolish in front of another person.

In *ACOMAF*, when Rhysand takes Feyre to Velaris, he is revealing to her far more than simply the city itself. He is giving her access to the most protected secret he owns. Velaris has been kept hidden from the rest of Prythian for five thousand years. By taking Feyre to Velaris, Rhysand is entrusting her with the one place that displays who he truly is, beyond the cruel persona he presents in almost every other part of his world. The way she reacts to the vibrant street life, the theatres, the music that resonates with what he communicated to her mentally during her confinement; all of it helps to redefine him. The city *is* the confession. The host does not have to say “this is who I really am” as the very geography speaks for him.

This can happen on a much smaller level. In *Bridgerton* (Season 2 / *The Viscount Who Loved Me*), a thunderstorm sends Kate Sharma into the library at Aubrey Hall, Anthony’s family estate. She is petrified, cowering under a desk, and Anthony discovers her in his own domain but at a time when the power dynamics of their relationship have entirely broken down. The ancestral library, full of Bridgerton history, becomes a sanctuary where Anthony provides Kate with the quiet comfort of holding her hand and waiting patiently with her until the storm passes. A public area would have required a sense of propriety. A bedroom would have created scandal. At nighttime in the library, they can find a private area without crossing boundaries, and the vulnerability of that moment forever changes the course of their contentious interactions.



Does one character visit the other's home territory?

Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide?

When one character visits the other's world, who visits whom? What does the visitor notice first? What is the host proud of — and what would they rather hide? What everyday moment creates unexpected intimacy?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?

What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the “native” character see their home differently through the visitor’s eyes?

Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?

Place explains people. What becomes clear about your love interest once you see where they grew up?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

Distance lends an air of seriousness. When characters can go anywhere instantly, then being apart has little consequence. If you’re travelling for weeks, then every time your characters leave each other, it counts.

Travelling is not a series of boring scenes to get your characters from point A to point B before they hit the next big plot point. It's the place where all your characters' relationships grow. Travel removes the artificial social boundaries we place around our lives and puts us in a position of shared vulnerability: sleeping close enough to touch, being tired and cranky around each other, having to rely on each other to survive or navigate. Your characters will become intimate with each other out of necessity. One person helping to care for another's blisters. Two people sharing body heat to stay warm in the cold camp. The required closeness of a small boat or a narrow trail where two people can't help but brush against one another.

Also, capture the rhythm of the travel. Comfortable silences. Only talking to each other when there's really nothing else to do. How danger brings your characters closer together than safety could ever hope to. And when you write about separation by distance, show the weight of separation by what your characters *can't* do: letters arriving too late, slow news, the pain of not knowing anything about each other. A reunion after a long period of separation hits much harder than a reunion after a short time apart.

In *From Blood and Ash*, the trip through the Blood Forest is where Poppy and Hawke develop as friends and romantic interests. The continuous threat of attack from Craven continually puts them on edge; however, it's the physicality of the journey that takes away Poppy's social role as the Maiden. She can't even ride a horse, so she rides behind him. They eat meals together by the campfire. The informal nature of the trail removes all formalities. As they continue their journey, Hawke begins to treat Poppy as a peer rather than a charge, and she finally reveals to him her deepest secret, her empathic magic, while nursing back to health a dying guard. It's the actual terrain of the road, not the individual conversations, that allows her to transition from sheltered figurehead to someone making her own decisions.

Fourth Wing *does the same thing during their flight to Athebyne. Violet and Xaden have to fly together because of the bond between their dragons, and the close proximity of dragonback travel (they are constantly touching, they have to share body heat, no way to create distance mid-flight) tears down the emotional walls they've put up. By the time they reach the outpost, Violet trusts Xaden as a person, not because of his rank at Basgiath. She trusts him because of the things they both endured during the flight to Athebyne.*



How do people typically travel in your world?

The mode of travel shapes intimacy. Dragonback forces touching. A carriage allows conversation. Walking side by side is different from riding single-file. What does your world's travel look like — and what proximity does it create?

What is the primary mode of travel in your world? Who uses it, and what kind of physical proximity does it create between your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel Time Reference

These are real-world estimates. Feel free to adjust for your world — magic, flying creatures, or difficult terrain will change things.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15-20 miles / 25-32 km	Healthy adult with breaks
Forced march	25-30 miles / 40-50 km	Exhausting, not sustainable
Riding (sustainable)	25-35 miles / 40-55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40-50 miles / 65-80 km	Tiring the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80-100 miles / 130-160 km	Fresh mounts at stations
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100-150 miles / 160-240 km	Highly variable

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles / 32-50 km	Roads required

How long does travel take between key locations?

Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

How long does it take to travel between your key locations — capital to border, one character's home to the other's, and across the dangerous region?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?

The road is where walls come down. What would a long journey together reveal about each of them?

Describe the most important journey in your story. Where does it go, how long does it take, and what happens between your characters during the journey?

YOUR ANSWER

Isolated Locations

Isolation is romance's secret weapon. When characters can't leave, they can't avoid each other, and avoidance is the enemy of romantic development. Isolated settings force confrontation, require cooperation, and create the kind of pressure that transforms reluctant attraction into something undeniable.

It helps to establish early on why leaving isn't an option, and to make that reason feel real and insurmountable. Once that is established, you can then use the confined space to your advantage. Which rooms do all of the characters have access to? How small are the hallways? What common resources require collaboration? Write the claustrophobia alongside the intimacy, because while being isolated may develop an attraction between the two, that attraction may be hidden from the surface due to resentment toward the closeness caused by the isolation.

Have fun with this, too. On a ship, there's nowhere to go after an argument, so you're eating breakfast together whether you like it or not. At an academy, the professor keeps pairing them for sparring

practice. In a snowed-in estate, someone has to share a bed because the guest wing is freezing. The setting should be generating its own little problems. Let it do some of the storytelling work for you. And remember: when characters finally *could* leave but choose to stay, that choice is a declaration.



What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

Describe an isolated or trapped location in your world. What kind of place is it, why do people end up there, and what makes leaving difficult?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the isolation generate romantic pressure?

Isolation alone isn't enough — it's the logistics of confinement that force intimacy. What about this space means your characters can't avoid each other? Think about shared meals, narrow corridors, mandatory pairings, limited beds, communal bathing, arguments with nowhere to storm off to.

In your trapped/isolated setting, what space must the characters share? What daily routine forces interaction? Where do they go after an argument when there's nowhere to go? At what point could they leave — and what does choosing to stay mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Geography as Emotional Landscape

The physical world may support, or oppose, the emotional journey that is happening in your story. A romantic encounter would feel very different if it were happening in a sunny field versus a ruined castle. A confession made during a storm would have much greater emotional impact than a confession made while everything was quiet.

The settings you choose can be directly connected to the emotional beats in your story, or they can be deliberately opposite. If you choose to use a setting which is emotionally charged (for example, a first kiss in a threatening location), you will give your story a sense of urgency. The same kiss in a serene garden would convey safety and a sense of choice. Pathetic fallacy can be effective when it is used judiciously: a storm during a confrontation and sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile. Even more subtle, however, is the idea that characters see the same landscape in different

ways depending on their emotional state. A person who is in love might see beauty in every rock and tree. A person who is broken-hearted might see the same landscape as empty and unattractive.

Creating “their place” can also be a powerful thing to do. This refers to a location which becomes sacred to the relationship, whether it’s where they first met, first kissed, or where they weathered some kind of disaster together. When characters return to these meaningful locations, the reader should be able to pick up on the emotional resonance without needing to be told why. A single line, something like “She hadn’t been back to the bridge since that night,” can convey a lot of emotional information to the reader, especially if you had previously established that the bridge was a significant location.

Stephenie Meyer, author of *Twilight*, built the entire premise of the book around this principle. She selected the city of Forks, Washington specifically because it is one of the rainiest, cloudiest places in the country. The rain does more than provide atmosphere; it provides the vampires with the ability to live in plain sight, and it is also symbolic of the dreamlike, suspended quality of Bella’s life once she meets Edward. In addition to the rain, the Meadow is another key setting. It is a sunlit clearing within the surrounding forest, the one place where the clouds break and Edward can reveal himself fully to Bella. Over the course of the story, the Meadow becomes a symbolically important location to the relationship. When Edward leaves in *New Moon*, it is described as withered and dying, and the reader understands that the death of the Meadow reflects the state of the romance. The state of the place is an indicator of the health of the love story.

In *Fourth Wing*, the use of emotional geography is taken further. Violet’s lightning and Xaden’s shadows are not simply metaphorical representations of their emotional states, but are actually manifestations of those states. When the intensity of their emotions finally reaches a boiling point, it manifests physically in the destruction of the space around them. Furniture is destroyed, the room shakes. The physical space around them literally cannot hold the emotional energy of the connection they share. While that’s an extreme version of the principle, the craft lesson remains the same. When the world responds to the romance, readers will feel the emotion in their bodies, as opposed to simply understanding the emotion intellectually.



What's the emotional quality of your primary setting?

The emotional quality of a place shapes every scene that happens there. An oppressive setting adds urgency to a first kiss; a serene one implies safety and choice. Does your primary setting feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying — and how does that quality interact with your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the environment ever mirror or oppose your characters' emotions?

A storm during a confrontation, sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile, a wilting garden reflecting a dying relationship. Where could your setting respond to the emotional beats of your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

*Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?
A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that's "theirs":*

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

How does your geography connect to other aspects of your world? Consider: Does it create the friction type you identified? How does it explain cultural differences? How does it create power structures? How does it interact with magic? What resource or territory is contested?

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
<i>Key location 1</i>	<i>The Winter Court — where protagonist is hostage and love interest is prince</i>
Key location 1	
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The dangerous region	
The isolated location	
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	
Other:	
Other:	

Map Making (Optional)

You don't need a map. Plenty of great fantasy stories were written without one.

That said, maps can help you keep travel times consistent and visualise where things are in relation to each other. If you decide to make one, let your story's needs guide you. How far is the border your characters are fleeing towards? Is the palace defensible? Where might lovers meet in secret? Build your geography around the situations your plot requires.

Map-Making Tools

Free options unless noted. Search these names online for current links.

- **Inkarnate** Popular fantasy map maker (free tier available)
- **Azgaar's Fantasy Map Generator** Procedural generation with editing
- **Wonderdraft** One-time purchase, professional quality
- **Donjon** Random generators for maps and dungeons
- **World Anvil** Worldbuilding wiki with map tools (subscription)

Map Making: What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to

— ◆ —

The geography of your world is about much more than where everything is. It's why your characters can't be together easily, and what they'll have to cross, endure, or sacrifice to change that. The mountain range is why two peoples distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route. The isolated academy is why two people who would never have spoken are now sharing a corridor. Build geography that explains your world and creates the pressure your romance needs.